were established by the US itself. The disarray and fragmentation of the West was also evident in Brexit. At the Nineteenth CPC Congress in 2019, Xi Jinping reflected this new assessment in declaring that China 'would become a leading country in comprehensive national strength and international influence', and that the new era would be one that 'sees China moving closer to the world's centre stage'. [7]

China was no longer defensive about its communist ideology and authoritarian state. Xi presented China as a model that could be followed by developing countries. 'China,' he said, 'offers a new option for other countries and nations who want to speed up their development while preserving their independence.' [8]

The change in the international balance of power, in what Xi describes as a 'new era', recognizes that technology plays a key role in geopolitical contestation. [9] The world is said to be in the midst of the 'fourth industrial revolution', centred on new-age technologies, and China, it is claimed, is ahead of the global technology curve. The Chinese government regularly publishes policy documents, known as White Papers, which are authoritative declarations of current policies. They cover overall national policy as well as policy on specific issues such national defence and Tibet. The Defence White Paper published in 2019 [10] stated,

'China is catching up and getting ahead.'

It also said the '. . . relationship between technology and power is at the core of changes unseen in a century'.

In 2015, China announced its ten-year Made in China 2025 plan, which specified ten high-tech industries in which China would attempt to achieve global dominance. These are artificial intelligence, quantum computing, electric vehicles, robotics, aerospace, biotechnology, semi-conductors, pharmaceuticals, and agricultural equipment and machinery. More recently, a timeline has been indicated for some goals to be achieved, such as the building of 5G networks across China by 2020 (a goal that has been achieved), China's becoming a world leader in AI by 2030 and dominating standard-setting in different domains by 2035. Reports from US think tanks acknowledge that China may be ahead of the US in AI, quantum computing